

Text One

My Goose, Willy

adapted from an article by Paul Theroux

In this passage Paul Theroux, a famous author, writes about looking after an orphaned and abandoned young bird.



The first moving creature Willy saw was me, and he snuggled in my hand, and when I put him in a warm cage I kept it at eye level and made sure he had plenty to eat. He doubled in size in ten days, and within a month grew tiny feathers, and then fledged¹ in earnest, spiky feathers that gave him bulk and turned him white. When I held him I could feel his pulsing heart, his warm body. And very soon, when I said, 'Willy', he responded with a little caw.

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For the first time since my children finished school my writing day was changed, brightened in unexpected ways. Willy was to be attended to, fed with pellets, the horse trough filled with water so he could climb in and splash, diving, beating his wings and then grooming himself as he dried off in the sun, pecking at his feathers, combing them smooth with his beak.

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Willy lingered near the door of my studio and squawked in recognition when I appeared at lunchtime to feed him by hand. Often he simply lingered, working his beak, sniffing, lowering his head and lengthening his neck if another goose came near, possessive of me.

Willy served as my protector and would often chase away any male goose that assumed a threat posture or aimed his beak at my shins. Unlike the others, Willy could be stillness itself, satisfied with food, when I rested with him after my own lunch on the low lava stone wall and stroked his feathers. The density of down over a goose's breast is a pillow of warmth you can sink your fingers into.

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He hurried to me when I called him by name. On my arrival at the long driveway he emitted a squawk of recognition from a hundred yards away when the iron wheels of the entrance gate clanked against their rail. I might have been away for months, but when I returned he flew to me, low to the ground and settled by my side. Geese vocalise in various ways; I grew to know the sounds he made – the caw of contentment, the shriek, the harsh squawk, the hiss, and loudest of all the trumpeting after overcoming an adversary. Now and then Willy opened and shut his beak without a sound, as though in a silent stammer. 20 25

Like the other geese, he spent a good part of his day preening, cleaning and ordering his feathers with his beak. Geese bathe rather than swim, diving and immersing their heads, and beating their wings in the water to clean them. 30

Willy remained mild-tempered and protective, often occupying a sheltered spot near the garage, nibbling grass, or – as all geese seem to do – testing the greenery of any plants within a beak's reach, devouring some, leaving bite marks on others. He became a fixture, in the grassy acre, at the house, near the studio, in my life – a certainty, dependable and unassertive, as true as a compass point, but looming, a graceful ornament, a marble figure set on a conspicuous plinth, just as lovely, the whiteness of his feathers giving him a marble-like quality. Yet he was a living ornament, squawking when he saw me in the morning, strutting to his chosen spot to be fed; and then at one o'clock when I left my studio calling out again; awake when I locked up at night, usually waiting by the gate on my return after a few hours, or six months. In those days and weeks when I felt uninspired and superfluous as a writer he was a consolation. 35 40

No night-time sight can compare with the singular beauty of a pure white goose, or several – their motionless, luminous shapes on dark moonstruck grass that absorbs the light, the contrast of each bird's brilliance, glowing as if lit from within.

It was my belief that Willy wasn't like other geese. He was himself: distinctive, intelligent, resourceful, loyal, self-sufficient when I was away, dependent when I was at home, healthy, able to defend himself against the other geese, knowing when to fight and when to give them a wide berth. 45

I often thought: if only people knew what my geese are like when I am alone with them – the solitary pleasure that only the pet-owner is privileged to know. It is impossible for anyone except the owner to see the creature as it actually is, because in the presence of others the animal behaves differently – fusses, gets nervy and loud or silly or hostile, playing the fool as children often do in the presence of strangers. No one knows except the parent, or pet-owner, what a marvel the creature is, when resting and that when you're alone you are nearly always at peace – such intelligence and serenity and mutual understanding the visitor never sees. 50 55

Glossary

¹ *fledged* – developed mature feathers

Text Two

Rescue To Recovery: Raising an Orphan Elephant

adapted from an article on The Sheldrick Wildlife Trust website

In this passage, the writer describes how young orphaned elephants are looked after.



Rescue

When we receive a call about an orphaned infant wild animal in need, it doesn't matter where they are in the country, we'll use whatever transportation is necessary including vehicle, aircraft or helicopter to reach them and bring them to the safety of our Nursery.

Being orphaned is a profoundly traumatic event, both physically and psychologically, and many orphans suffer from starvation, dehydration or injuries caused by predators or humans. Our rescue teams are equipped with milk, stretchers to carry the orphan, and vital medicines including drips, to offer immediate aid at the scene and during the rescue.

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Recovery

Caring for elephants is a round-the-clock, day-in-and-day-out commitment.

At our Nursery, based in Nairobi National Park, we offer a secure base and a loving environment to nurture these orphans at a time of greatest need and our human carers play a vital role in helping the new arrivals through this difficult period.

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Our Keepers play a crucial part in supporting and nurturing the orphans as their lost mothers would have done. They offer them unconditional love, emotional support and the learning experiences that each young elephant needs to grow, as they would have received from their absent mothers. The Keepers care for the orphans 24 hours a day and this includes sleeping with the orphans during the night in their individual stockades on a rotational basis so they do not feel alone.

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